Group 16

4TH FEB 2026

WILD LEATHER

EXOTIC LEATHER & BIO-DIVERSITY LOSS

COURSE

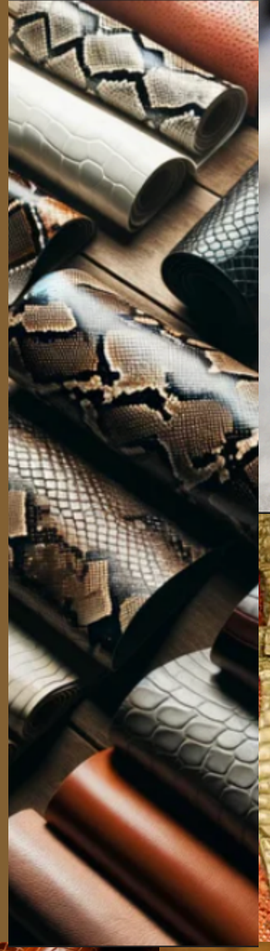
GLOBAL ENTREPRENEURSHIP AND SUSTAINABLE BUSINESS

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Wildlife to Wardrobe





WHAT HAPPENED?

- Exotic leather is a major global industry, with 1.5+ million crocodilian skins traded legally every year.
- The CNN article we focused on discusses Inversa leather, an alternative material that some companies are adopting instead of exotic leather.
- Demand is driven largely by luxury fashion and accessories
- Alongside legal trade, wildlife crime generates $7–$23 billion annually
- Illegal skins are frequently laundered through legal supply chains, blurring legality
- Luxury brands sit at the intersection of conservation, crime, and consumption.



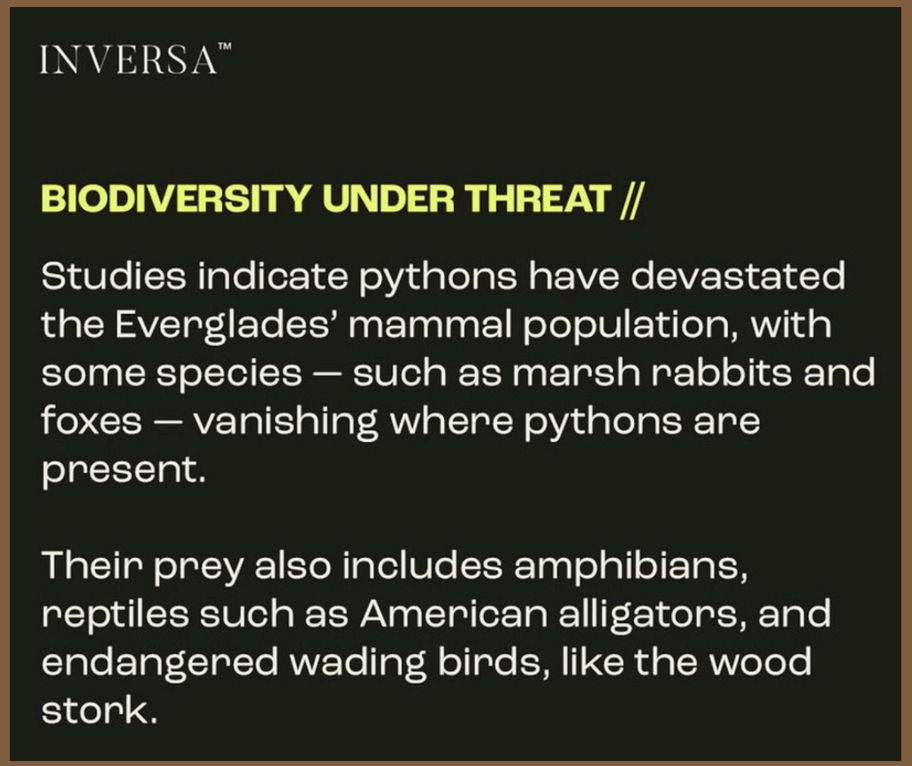




THE WICKED PROBLEM

Wicked Dimension	Evidence
Illegal laundering	30–50% of global wildlife trade is illegal or illegally laundered
Enforcement gap	>40% of CITES members lack adequate enforcement capacity
Crime method	~90% of wildlife crime cases involve document fraud
Ecological scale	$423B annual global damage from invasive species

(UNODC, 2020; CITES SC, 2022; IPBES, 2023)



DRIVERS

- Luxury status & scarcity
- Weak governance
- Traditional livelihood & craft knowledge
- Global Warming

STAKEHOLDER TENSIONS

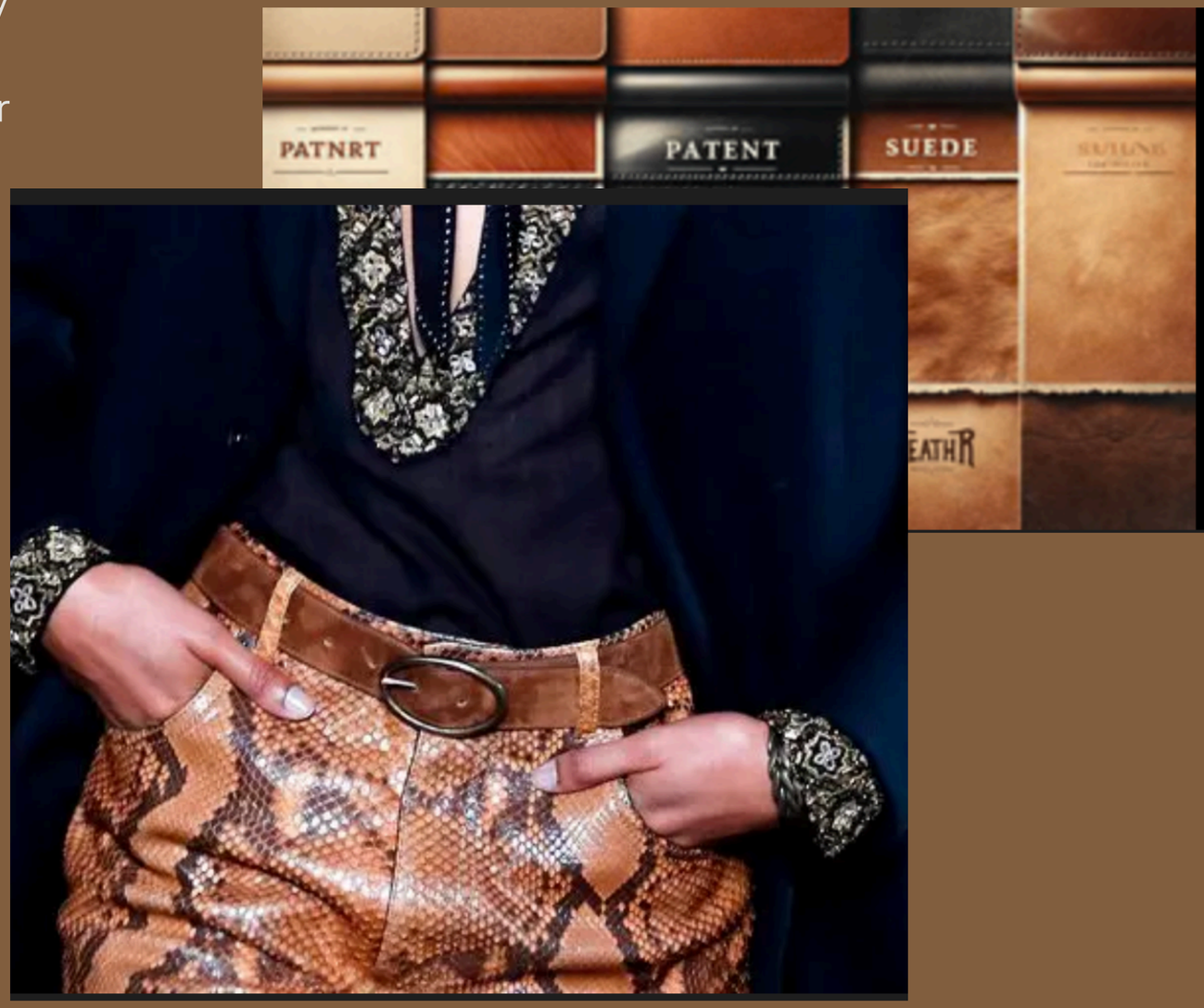
- Conservation NGOs (ecosystem protection) vs. Luxury Brands(differential & margins)
- Governments (balancing biodiversity commitments & rural employment)
- Indigenous Communities (cultural rights & income) vs Endangered species advocates
- Consumers(sustainability claims vs actual purchasing decisions)

IMPLICATIONS

SO WHAT?

- Luxury brands face growing scrutiny over biodiversity impacts across their value chains
- Many companies are already taking steps to source leather more ethically, including:
  – stricter supplier standards, certified farms and tanneries.
- Brands are also reducing total leather use through:

– smaller product volumes, thinner cuts, and waste reduction



RISKS & CONSTRAINTS

- Rising risk: reputational and regulatory exposure linked to biodiversity loss
- Supply pressure: fewer certified leather sources, higher costs, more volatility
- Opportunity: ethical sourcing protects brand equity and consumer trust
- Innovation upside: reduced leather use and alternatives improve resilience
- Hard constraint: leather remains central to luxury identity and demand

PROPOSED ACTION





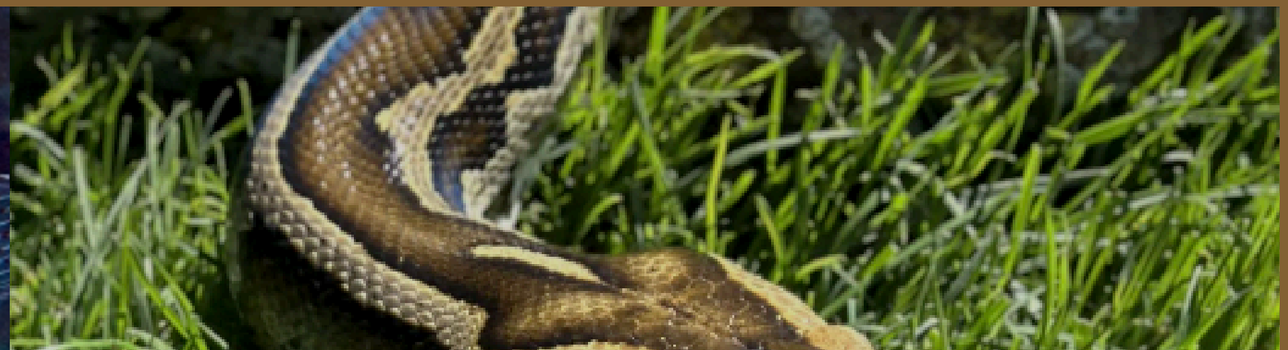
What is the action?

- Turning Invasive Species into a Biodiversity Tool
- Shift luxury leather sourcing away from endangered or farmed species
- Source skins from invasive species whose removal supports ecosystem recovery
  - Examples: Burmese pythons (Florida Everglades), lionfish (Caribbean reefs)
- Reframe leather use from biodiversity harm to ecosystem management.

Who are invloved?

- Luxury brands: decide to adopt invasive-species leather and integrate it into design and sourcing strategies.
- Wildlife & invasive-species agencies: identify invasive species, set removal rules, and ensure ecological goals are met.
- Tanneries & processors: convert raw skins into usable leather while maintaining quality and traceability.
- Conservation NGOs & trade regulators: validate ecological benefits and prevent illegal wildlife trade.







IS IT ETHICAL FOR LUXURY BRANDS TO MARKET LEATHER AS A SYMBOL OF STATUS DESPITE ITS ENVIRONMENTAL COSTS?